EXHIBITION ▼

A Rare Window

FLASHBACK, KETAKI SHETH'S EXHIBITION OF MONOCHROME PHOTOGRAPHS AT PHOTO-INK DELHI, IS AN INTIMATE LOOK AT INDIAN FILMMAKING IN THE 1980S AND 1990S

Photographs courtesy : KETAKI SHETH AND PHOTOINK



FROZEN IN TIME 'Rekha on the set of *Souten ki Beti*', 1988 (top) and 'At home with Sunny Deol', 1989

There is something quietly radical about returning to the film sets of the 1980s and early 1990s without colour. In *Flashback*, Ketaki Sheth revisits the film worlds of Bombay and Madras between 1985 and 1993 through a suite of black and white photographs.

Sheth's unusual access to the industry came largely through accompanying the respected film critic Khalid Mohamed. Stars trusted him, and that trust extended to her. Younger aspirants, eager for visibility, welcomed her presence, while technicians and crew appeared quietly pleased to find the camera trained on them rather than solely on marquee names. The result is a body of work that gently redistributes attention across the ecosystem of filmmaking and foregrounds the collaborative spirit sustaining cinematic illusion.

Fresh from her studies at New York University in 1984, Sheth approached the industry with curiosity rather than calculation. "I didn't think too much about mythology and the industry," she reflects. "I just wanted to make good pictures."

Beginning in the heady milieu of 1980s Bombay and extending to Madras, where Sheth later worked independently and with greater confidence, *Flashback* presents what she describes as "portraits of individuals caught between performance and reality". ■

—Nikhil Sardana

The exhibition is on till March 17

EXHIBITION ▼

MAXIMUM CITY

SUDARSHAN SHETTY'S SOLO SHOW IN DELHI CELEBRATES MUMBAI'S THROBBING PULSE

Photo courtesy : GALLERYSKE



INTO THE WILD A still from Sudarshan Shetty's 'A Breath Held Long'

New Delhi's Galleryske is currently hosting artist Sudarshan Shetty's new solo exhibition *A Breath Held Long*, which includes a 31-minute film of the same name alongside a set of new sculptures based around the concepts explored in the film. The short film, shot in black and white on 16mm celluloid, blends documentary techniques with elements of theatre and classical music. Mumbai is presented as a city perpetually on the move via buses and trains, even as a mixture of professional actors and amateurs recite short, fictional monologues with no punctuation.

"The exhibition's concept began with those texts that you see the actors reading," says Shetty. "They are also the texts displayed in my stainless steel sculptures. I wrote them many years ago... they came to me fully formed as fictional monologues about life and death. The name of the exhibition, 'A Breath Held Long', came from the fact that if these punctuation-free monologues were to be performed for the screen, the performers would have to hold their breath for a long time."

A FILM THAT IS PART OF THE SHOW BLENDS DOCUMENTARY TECHNIQUES WITH THEATRE AND CLASSICAL MUSIC

One of the monologues in the film, for example, talks about the controlled destruction of an unstable building—the concept being reinforced by sculptures depicting abandoned objects, broken utensils, old clothes submerged in water and so on. In perhaps the film's most memorable and surprising moment, a trained female classical singer bursts into song on a crowded bus. Initially hesitant, her co-passengers start joining her, one by one, until the entire bus is harmonising.

"The passengers on the bus are all trained actors and I gave them very little direction other than to follow the singer's lead," recalls Shetty. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

The exhibition is on till March 17